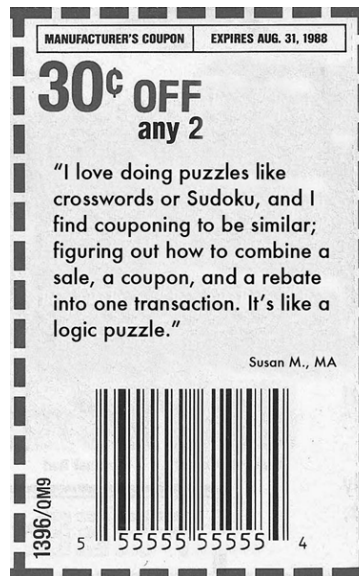




Vyrl Market, Inc. had been running a test to find out how people would react to coupons shared among friends in a social community. They planted fifteen different coupons for items such as yogurt, vitamins, and snacks on a new commercial application on Facebook. The hope was that Facebook users would see the coupons and start passing them along to friends. The majority of the images used were downloaded from the Internet, most without the permission of the manufacturers. As the test was getting underway, the coupons were copied and manipulated for different amounts by computer hackers, then posted for people to download. Even my introduction to Facebook was marred by coupon fraud. Fortunately, I hadn't downloaded any of the coupons, thinking it had sounded too good to be true. Which, of course, it was.

Retailers were learning about the new world of coupons right along with the consumer. When Target initially began issuing their own store-printable coupons that could be combined with manufacturer's coupons, they didn't limit the amount of coupons customers could print out and redeem. People